The Mihai Eminescu Trust

www.mihaieminescutrust.org

NEWSLETTER 2004

SIGHISOARA CONFERENCE

On 15-16 November, the MET, together with the United Nations Development Programme, organised the first stakeholders' conference for Sighisoara and the Saxon Villages. The turnout was overwhelming, with over 150 participants in Sighisoara's Town Hall. More than 15 NGOs, international agencies and private sector companies presented over 40 projects, some of which received immediate funding. The conference ended with the 'Sighisoara Declaration', affirming the intention of all the participants to continue to work together for the advancement of the region.



Minister Farcas (r) joins Jessica Douglas-Home, Jonathan Scheele, Soknan Han Jung and Owaise Saadat.

President Ion Iliescu's introductory message said: *"What is important is to set priorities and agree a timetable for completing the projects, especially in areas where urgent action is needed to stop degradation and highlight valuable cultural sites. I've discussed these projects with Prince Charles, who is a true friend of Romania, and with Jessica Douglas-Home, the president of the Mihai Eminescu Trust, and I am confident that things will go the right way. The launch of pilot projects, such as the Whole Village and the establishment of protected areas, could be replicated throughout the region as a school for those who want to specialise in sustainable economic development and environmental protection."* Jonathan Scheele, head of the EC delegation, said: *"Sighisoara and the surrounding villages can be part of a new approach, careful of not destroying bonds and going from the bottom up. This approach is - dare I say it - completely different from the one of Dracula Park."*

Previously, our patron, HRH The Prince of Wales, opening the Conference by video, had said: *"I am enormously proud of what has been achieved by the MET to date and I believe that the expansion and development of initiatives in this unique region provides the best way forward for an economically viable, long-term future of Transylvania's unspoilt natural and built heritage. But of course none of this would be possible without the generous support of many organisations as well as many dedicated individuals."*

Our aim was to draw together key actors from outside and within Transylvania to review the main regional issues and to assess and kickstart plans for dealing with the most pressing needs. In *agricultural and economic development* and *environmental protection*, we welcomed representatives from NGOs and local and national government, who presented briefs ranging from the creation of Farmer Associations to the development of organic brands; in *restoration and conservation of built heritage*, 16 organisations participated; and in *local governance and the development of civil society*, nine local mayors and councillors from throughout the region attended. The result was significant progress in getting the most viable and urgent projects funded.

TRAINING

* Ian Pritchett, who runs a conservation building practice near Reading, came with us on our February planning and preparation visit.

* Master stonemason Henry Rumbold and conservation expert Steve Finney visited the villages from April until November on a monthly basis. Steve trained builders to save and reconstruct three derelict houses in Crit and continued to help with the tower in Bunesti. Henry instructed on buildings and churches in both communes.

* We proudly announce our first lady builder. The quality of her work on Viscri church made a deep impression on our chief architect.

* An international British/Romanian Diploma training programme is being prepared for the Trust in 2005 by Henry Rumbold. This will result in certified qualifications for plasterers, carpenters, stonemasons, bricklayers and foremen under the aegis of the National Heritage Training Group, the Bucharest School of Architecture and the Romanian Government.
* Training in our organic orchard has proceeded throughout the spring and summer under the expert tutelage of Wili Tartler.
* Following Marian Suhr's excellent MET document on restoration procedure in Transylvanian villages, Ned Scharer, on a travelling fellowship from the Winston Churchill Memorial Trust, has produced another training document - the history and present day practice of lime mortar colour. He based himself in Crit to analyse the many-layered texture of buildings in the surrounding towns and villages.

RESTORATION & CONSERVATION

General

Once again, a vast amount of restoration and training has been accomplished in our 15 villages, with work proceeding on no less than 75 projects, including seven churches (five Lutheran, one Hungarian Catholic and one Romanian Orthodox). Our architect, Gabriel Lambescu, has documented and overseen all these operations - an astonishing feat. We wish to convey our gratitude for his meticulous professionalism. At Saxon gatherings in Viscri and Mesendorf and earlier in the year in Bunesti he gave presentations about the work of the Trust, describing our objectives and methodology, based on our philosophy of repairing as found, without altering original structures.



MALANCRAV 297 - BEFORE (LEFT) AND AFTER

Malancrav Manor House

* Great progress has been made. The west wing is completed, the columns being constructed with hand-made bricks from Sighisoara and the bricks for the walls and roof tiles being hand-made and fired in traditional wood burning kilns in the Hungarian area of Transylvania. On 16 October Fritz Klusch and Ernst Linzing (who was elected councillor in Laslea commune, in June) made speeches and presided over a reception at the Manor House to commemorate the completion of the new roof - a spray of flowers was placed on the topmost rafters.
* We have planted the first part of the avenue on the track to the Manor.



THE MANOR'S NEW WEST WING

Sighisoara

* The Trust has bought a house - "the Tower House" - on the ramparts of the citadel. Work on its restoration will start during the winter.



THE TOWER HOUSE

* We are offering to restore the adjoining Leather Coat Makers' Tower. The World Bank is restoring another tower nearby.
* The Trust has acquired a first floor flat for its own use overlooking the central square of the citadel. Work on it was completed during the summer.
* Funded by an MET grant, Edmund Handy made his first visit to repair the Samuel Maetz clavichord in the Sighisoara museum. Well known as a fine maker and restorer of early keyboard instruments, he has over 20 years of experience in the history, construction and conservation of clavichords. He will return to finish work on the instrument in 2005, observed by two Sighisoaran musicians.

Churches

* In Mesendorf six dangerous fractures in the walls of the church were repaired. Other large-scale work was completed on 14 buttresses and the four entrances, in collaboration with HOG (the departed Saxon community in Germany).
* In Cloasterf church major work was done on four bastions (one of which had collapsed) and the exterior wall. We have also shored up the entrance beside the bell-ringer's house.
* Research into the history of the Hungarian Church in Malancrav has revealed that it was built in 1865 with the help of the widow of the last private owner of Malancrav Manor House - Joseph Haller. The roof was in very poor condition and has now been repaired.
* The careful rebuilding of the collapsed tower at Bunesti church is nearly completed - our work was held up by nesting storks.
* Reparation of the Cloasterf Romanian Orthodox church is complete.

Protected Areas Scheme

* Gabriel Lambescu and the biologist, Minodora Holban, completed a preliminary study for the establishment of Bunesti and Laslea Natural Parks: the project was presented and approved at the Sighisoara Conference. Together with the Laslea and Bunesti councils we hope to establish the first pilot schemes in 2005.

AGRICULTURAL PRODUCE, HANDICRAFTS AND SMALL BUSINESSES

Guesthouse Tourism

* Our Landmark Trust/MET guesthouses have had a very good first year in Viscri, Malancrav, Crit and Cloasterf, with over 400 guest nights booked. Visitors ranged from a member of the British Government's Parliamentary Cabinet Counsel Office to the head of London's National Portrait Gallery. The latter stayed in Viscri and wrote: *"...I am full of admiration for the work of the Trust and all that it is doing to maintain the life and fabric of the Saxon villages of Transylvania"*.



OUR GUESTHOUSE IN CRIT

* Another visitor to Malancrav, the writer Jonathan Gathorne Hardy, wrote: *" The house and village were delightful. The people we met were very hospitable, the cooking was wonderful (as was the wine!) and the whole experience was one we shall treasure for a long time to come"*.
* Our restored house in the central square in Biertan has now returned to its previous existence as a shop: Artefact Biertan is open seven days a week from March to October, selling lace, embroidery, apple juice, honey, calendars, postcards, icons, glass paintings and rugs - all locally made. In the spring we will be letting Landmark/MET guesthouse rooms in the courtyard of this house.



NEW CRAFTS SHOP IN THE CENTRAL SQUARE OF BIERTAN

* Many tourist groups have returned to Romania through the Trust. Following Abercrombie and Kent's successful visit last year, they again came to Biertan.

* We have helped Transylvania Uncovered to create a stand to promote Romanian tourism at the World Trade Fair in Olympia next year.
* We have taken our first guesthouse bookings for the Christmas period and hope this grows into an all-season business for the villages.

Organic agricultural produce

* In May we obtained the final permissions to sell our organic apple juice throughout Romania. It was an arduous task - our thanks to Ioan Petcu, Ernst Linzing and Ben Mehedin for seeing this through. Our juice went on sale in Bucharest and is popular in shops, restaurants and hotels in Sighisoara, Medias and Sibiu. In particular, we appreciate our collaboration with Bio-Coop Sibiu-Ferma Schuster. We have had a generous grant from the David Blacker memorial fund to subsidise the juice on sale in some Saxon villages, enabling the children to drink something other than artificial fizzy drinks.



ORGANIC APPLE JUICE FROM MALANCRAV IS ON SALE COUNTRYWIDE

* In November Ioan Petcu attended Indagra 2004, the Food and Drink Expo in Bucharest, to raise awareness about organic agriculture and its products. The apple juice was much admired and appeared on Romania's national TVR1.
* The Malancrav orchard team have been grafting rare local specimens for our historic collection as well as creating a nursery for special species.
* For the first time, we are producing our own organic honey in Malancrav orchard. We hope to have plenty to sell next year.

Handicrafts and small businesses

* The MET gave a grant to a hand-made and fired bricks and tiles business, to encourage its growth and the continued use of traditional wood burning kilns in the Hungarian area of Transylvania.
* We have supported the work of an embroiderer and carpet-maker in Malancrav and have arranged for three young trainees to be taught her skills.
* Three village blacksmiths attended an equine management course in Fagaras given by Julian Ross.
* 20 guesthouse owners/workers/cooks have been trained in Viscri. They have received their diplomas and can now operate independently. We hope to extend this programme to other villages and Sighisoara in 2005.
* We have given a grant for the acquisition and restoration of a mill and bakery, which will be put into working order and become a viable economic business for the benefit of Hosman, near Sibiu: profits from its operation will go to village and church remedial work.

PARTNERSHIP GRANTS

* The artist Celia Ward held her exhibition of watercolours, "Malancrav - Portrait of a Saxon Village" at the Cultural Institute in the Romanian Embassy, London. She spent two years visiting Malancrav, staying in one of the Trust's houses.
* On 14 July the renowned pianist Anda Anastasescu - in collaboration with the MET - arranged a brass quintet concert of classical and modern composers in Biertan. The musicians were from British music schools (Chetham's School Brass Quintet, The Morgan Quintet and a quintet from Yehudi Menuhin's School). The MET arranged overnight accommodation in the church precincts and a dinner with music-lovers from the village. Anda reported back: *"It was really a success! There were about 40-60 persons in the church, half young people, half older generations ... it was - and I hope will be so again - a good opportunity to educate the younger people from Biertan and Richis by showing them an alternative to the music they usually hear".*
* Our workman and architect have continued to help Pro Patrimonio with its Viscri house. The builders have also been helping a World Bank project in the village - restoring the church and the kindergarten.

* We gave the photographers of Mioritics Association a grant for their project to organise a "photo raid" throughout the Saxon Villages. As a result they held several exhibitions, including a three-day one in Biertan for the Saxons' annual meeting in September. Their photos can be seen at http://photoraid.dordeduca.ro.



BIERTAN CHURCH

* The Trust has sponsored and paid for the first part of research into the regeneration of the narrow gauge train between Sibiu, Agnita and Sighisoara.


LATE 19TH CENTURY SIGHISOARA

* We have given a projector, a telescope and a special listening device for bird watching to an ecological group in Sighisoara working on the Breite oak reservation project.

* We have collaborated again this year with Developing Technologies on their second visit to Romania to further the engineering design for horse-drawn haymaking machines. After testing with Julian Ross near Bistrita, the mower was ready for smooth land around Sighisoara but not yet secure enough for the undulating land around Lunca.

* The Trust has funded the publication of a book, in collaboration with GTZ, about the architectural details of doors, window and fixtures and fittings. This will be published in the next two months.

* We have given a donation for the organ in Hosman church. Special features there include the recently restored 16th century tower clock and the carved and painted 15th century doors.

* The MET supported the Romanian Cultural Centre in London in organising Ion Caramitru's trip to the UK, for the presentation of his film 'Stefan Luchian', on 9 March.

* During the summer, through a Trust grant, a Sighisoaran archivist researched 16th to 18th century Transylvanian village history in the State Archives in Sibiu, the Sighisoara library and the Teleki library in Tirgu Mures. He also researched the Apafi family who once owned the Malancrav Manor House.

* Once again we gave a donation to the German Journeymen's Guild house in Sibiu, enabling forty men and women to work in the towns and villages of Transylvania.

* The Trust and HRH The Prince of Wales have jointly funded a school minibus for Malancrav children travelling daily to Sighisoara.

* Two new villages are establishing village associations with grants from the MET, the first in Hosman.

* In October, Ian Pritchett gave an impressive talk on the work of the Trust in the Art Workers' Guild, London. It was attended by many people, some of whom afterwards gave generous donations. The Trust intends to put this money towards restoring a building in Floresti next season.

THE MARAMURES

* In February, William Blacker and Jessica Douglas-Home travelled to the north of the country to make a reconnaissance visit for HRH The Prince of Wales' 2004 spring visit to Romania. They found Barsana Monastery - the


BREB

ideal base from which the Prince could discover the Maramures.

* In early May, William Blacker led the royal group, including the botanist John Akeroyd, to walk through the hills, valleys and villages southwards. The Prince started his first day under the Gutin mountain near the three

Armenian peaks to attend the opening of the spring Stana with the village elders. During the two days, he visited Surdesti, Breb, Budesti and the church of Poenile Izei to see the extraordinary 17th century painted interior. While in Budesti, he visited a fulling mill and a distillery. He had lunch amongst a cluster of the Trust's restored houses.

* At the end of the visit, the Prince met President Ion Iliescu at Cotroceni Palace. The President was presented with a bottle of the Trust's organic apple juice.

PRIZES & AWARDS

* The MET has won first prize for "Innovation" in Responsible Tourism at an award ceremony at



MET - Best for Innovation in Responsible Tourism

the World Travel Market on the 10th of November.

* The MET has won the 'Diploma de Excelenta' from the Ministry of Culture. Caroline Fernolend (Bunesti Commune director), Fritz Klutsch (master builder in Noul Sasesc) and Gabriel Lambescu (chief architect) travelled to Bucharest on the 25th of May to receive it.

* Caroline Fernolend has also received the prestigious Ecce Homo prize in Poland for excellence in her field of work. Previous recipients include the Dalai Lama and Jacek Kuron. Completing a remarkable year of achievement, she was re-elected councillor in her commune.

* The MET office in Sibiu, Goldsmith's Square, was awarded the Romanian Architecture prize for restoration at the "Bienala de arhitectura romaneasca", organised by "Uniunea Arhitectilor din Romania".

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Once again our year's work owes everything to the generosity of our donors, especially the Packard Humanities Institute, Horizon Foundation and the Headley Trust. We are also grateful to the Lisbet Rausing Trust and Dr Sigrid Rausing.

In June, our Patron HRH The Prince of Wales played polo in Richmond in aid of the MET. We are most grateful for the sum raised, as we are for his other contributions to our work, which go far beyond the merely financial.

We have been given a present of 25 sets of tools from two British conservation businesses. We thank John Gibson of Historic Properties Restoration and Mike Moody (former President of the Stone Federation of Great Britain) of Classic Restoration Masonry. These tools are being delivered to Viscri in early spring for the new season ahead.

We thank the Mayor of Sighisoara for hosting the November conference and the donors who helped make the event possible - the Norwegian Embassy, GlaxoSmithKline, the British Council, Dan Dimancescu, Rodney Leach, Charlotte Heber-Percy, The Vicountess Boyd Trust, PwC, UBS, Linklaters, Banca Transilvania and CIMEC.

Finally, we offer our heartfelt gratitude to our outstanding Romanian team, whose achievements in 2004 have been repeatedly recognised by national and international awards.

FURTHER INFORMATION

The achievements in this newsletter are only made possible by your donations. Those made in the UK qualify for gift aid. We are a listed charity, No. 800590. Please send cheques to The Mihai Eminescu Trust, 63 Hillgate Place, London W8 7SS. For any information about our activities as well as books or brochures, please contact our London office at:
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